

Finding the 1826 Black Arts Renaissance: Activist Artists, Sacred Concerts, Music for Hayti, and Friday the 13th!

By Tyler Diaz

Published: December 13, 2024

Updated: December 18, 2024

Introduction

In the 1820s, racism barred Black audiences from cultural venues showcasing the arts on a grand scale, even though Black artists were sought after by White audiences for their talent. Black artists responded by creating a cultural shift within their communities. These figures were not merely entertainers—they were "activist architects of a cultural revolution, building societies that brought the Arts to their communities." This article traces how the African Harmonic Society pioneered sophisticated orchestra concerts that filled churches and public halls for decades.

Researching an Ad Leads us to A Whole Cultural Movement

An October 1826 advertisement in Poulson's American Daily Advertiser announced that members of the African Harmonic Society would hold their "FIRST SACRED CONCERT" on Friday the 13th. This marked the first publicly announced sacred music concert for Philadelphia's Black community.

The author discovered that 1826 was a significant year for Black entertainment in Philadelphia, prompting investigation into why this concert occurred and how the musicians came together.

Frank Johnson and James Hewlett's Philly-NYC Collab

James Hewlett, a celebrated Black actor and singer, spent nearly a month in Philadelphia in January 1826 performing before departing to England. Born in Rockaway, New York, Hewlett became one of the most successful stage actors of the 1820s, known for his Shakespeare interpretations and high-quality singing. He competed fiercely with leading White actor Edmund Kean.

Hewlett performed at A. Bonnaffon's dancing school on South Fourth Street on January 10th and 12th. Bonnaffon was also a patron of famous Black Philadelphia musician Frank Johnson. When Hewlett advertised his third performance on January 14th, he noted that the Johnson Band had volunteered their services.

Johnson subsequently took out an advertisement announcing that Hewlett was volunteering his services to a benefit concert for the band. This mutual support reflected "clear mutual admiration and respect" between the two artists. A contemporary account from bandleader William R. Bayley noted Johnson's exceptional deportment as a host.

Hewlett and Johnson reunited on August 14th, 1826, when Hewlett announced he would join the band for a performance in Saratoga Springs, where Johnson maintained a summer residency for over 20 years.

In 1826, Johnson increased his local dance ball engagements for White patrons and published several compositions. Two pieces stood out as commitments to representing the global fight against racism and colonization: "Recognition March on the Independence of Hayti" and "President Boyer's Cotillion," dedicated to Haiti's second president Jean-Pierre Boyer.

Fellow Black musician and barber James Hemmenway also published compositions dedicated to President Boyer's family, including "A Favorite Cotillion" dedicated to his daughter, Zema Boyer.

The sacred music concert following these performances and publications suggests Philadelphia's Black community was focused on honoring and supporting the arts.

Why an African Harmonic Society and Sacred Concerts?

Between 1825 and 1826, the African Harmonic Society formed in Philadelphia, including Johnson, his band, and their supporters. No constitution or bylaws survive, but their activities are informative.

Sacred music concerts were popular in White communities in New York and Philadelphia, emphasizing Christian hymns and church music by European composers. Sacred concerts in Philadelphia from 1821-1825 were typically held by churches and led by individuals. The Musical Fund Society, an organization of White musicians, presented such concerts.

Sacred concerts may have originated because of discrimination at White venues. While Black performers could perform in certain settings, "most of the time they could not attend." The musicians may have wanted to build a public music scene within the Black community.

This mirrors the founding of the African Theatre Company in New York. William A. Brown started the theater in 1821, and as scholar Yvonne Shafer notes, it was "formed in reaction to the negative conditions in the American theatre for Black actors and for Blacks wishing to attend plays."

The African Harmonic Society was Composed of Musicians and Non-Musicians Who Supported the Group

The next sacred concert occurred in April 1827 on Friday the 13th at First African Presbyterian Church. The advertisements listed both musician and non-musician supporters as ticket holders. In the later advertisement, Thomas Butler replaced Quamany Clarkson as a ticket holder, with Johnson and New York-based musician Jacob A. Stans added. Stans and Johnson worked together for at least eight years.

How Big Were the Concerts and What was Played?

First African Presbyterian Church could seat 900 people—comparable to the Walnut Street Theater's capacity of 1,054. Johnson would have directed professional musicians alongside amateur community members, forming a medium-sized orchestra of approximately 20 or more instrumentalists.

No program survives for the Friday the 13th concerts, but an October 2nd, 1827 setlist from a Black sacred music concert in New York provides insight into the repertoire. This program featured multiple works by established European composers and included performances by Philadelphia musicians visiting New York, and vice versa.

Why Friday, the 13th?

Friday the 13th has been associated with the occult and mysterious for centuries. The reasons for scheduling sacred concerts on this date remain unclear. Possibilities include efforts to help people overcome fear of the date, or connections to Masonic influences, since Frank Johnson was a Prince Hall Mason. These theories remain speculative.

Conclusion

Sacred music concerts in Philadelphia continued for decades. Through the African Harmonic Society's efforts, a musical scene developed within the Black community, allowing residents to experience diverse musical genres while giving Black artists platforms to share their talents. Musicians like Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield and Thomas Bowers of the next generation may have attended these concerts as children.

Other churches participated in this movement. St. Thomas church presented concerts in the early 1830s, while Mother Bethel AME did not engage with sacred music concerts until 1848, after William Appo led the orchestra with approval from Daniel Alexander Payne.

Concert programs from 1841 and 1846 illustrate the continuation of this tradition. The March 30th, 1841 "Grand Concert" was sponsored by the Philadelphia Library Company—a Black library company distinct from the current Philadelphia Library Company. At that time, "Black people were not allowed to join White cultural institutions in Philadelphia," where race relations were extremely fraught.

Frederick Douglass exemplified this discrimination in an 1870 letter rejecting a speaking invitation at the Academy of Music when he discovered Black audiences were excluded. He wrote that Philadelphia "stands almost alone in the intensity of its wolfish hate and snobbish pride of race."

Images

- AI imagining of the African Harmonic Society's Friday the 13th Concert — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b7728425217f4b31b231652a1c1dd6bd~mv2.jpg
- Ad in Poulson's American Daily Advertiser on October 12, 1826 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fc7b455e85d34501891c88e5f6afed88~mv2.jpeg
- Black Actor James Hewett — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e9318b920992415aa1ff9c549a824ec4~mv2.jpg
- Black Musician Frank Johnson — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/bb1adf_4514734bd72e478cbbd6cddd19f722fc~mv2.jpg
- President Jean-Pierre Boyer of Hayti — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/bb1adf_b15caa9d57604c6f83f77c12798fddf2~mv2.jpg
- Titles for Johnson's and Hemmenway's cotillions for the Boyer family — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/bb1adf_a7cabeb2142749bebf1c6299ddd6a4b9~mv2.jpg
- Worshipful Grand Historian Felix Gardenhire at Masonic Lodge Museum — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f6236fd9582d4aff8221ea5a026ea311~mv2.png
- Concert program, March 30, 1841 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_806a8cab4f744c66b84f4128adbe92b1~mv2.jpg
- Concert program, Friday, January 30, 1846 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f4ffbb9894f5454db178eb66f81a117a~mv2.jpg

- First African Presbyterian Church —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_11bda067eeec4dcc9f652891b0331ddb~mv2.jpg
- Ad in Freedom's Journal on September 28, 1827 —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/bb1adf_d8fc263ff55c4754ad7bc1382317c8fb~mv2.png

WORDCOUNT: 1,850